Shrinking World

Our experience of the world has been radically altered by modern technology. A journey that once took weeks by land or sea can now be flown in a matter of hours, and messages are transmitted around the world at the click of a mouse, giving us the impression that the world is becoming smaller.

BEFORE

Developments in communication and transportation in the 19th and early 20th centuries wrought new social, political, and economic ties between people living thousands of miles apart.

BETTER COMMUNICATION NETWORKS
British engineers **George Stephenson and Isambard Kingdom Brunel** contributed to the development of efficient rail transport systems, making travel across countries and continents faster and more affordable. Improvements to the size and speed of ocean-going ships increased the transport of freight around the world, while the success of wire-based telephone and telegraph systems allowed **instant communication** across physical space for the first time.

THE BIRTH OF TOURISM
Until the late 19th century, **tourism**, or recreational travel, was **the preserve of the better off**, but many more people were taking vacations by the 1900s. Companies such as Thomas Cook & Son, the first travel agent, began to organize **package tours**, including a "round-the-world trip."

Since World War I, advances in technology have transformed global communications and transportation systems, allowing both economic and personal connections to flourish on a worldwide scale. Without these technological developments, many features of modern life, including the phenomena of globalization (see pp.470–71) and global tourism, would not have occurred.

Revolutionizing travel

The 20th-century boom in travel was largely due to advances in the design of the internal combustion engine, which still powers most motor vehicles, ships, airplanes, and helicopters. The Ford Motor Company (see right) began to mass-produce combustion engines in 1906, pioneering "assembly lines" to speed up car production. Today motor manufacturing is a multi-billion-dollar industry. Global statistics predict that by 2030 there will be 1.2 billion motor vehicles in use worldwide.

As motor vehicles improved, so did road networks. The first "high-speed" intersection-free road, the *Automobil-Verkehrs- und Übungsstraße* (AVUS), was constructed in Berlin in 1912. Soon, multilane highways, such as Route 66, which runs from Chicago to Los Angeles, shortened travel times, allowing the transport of people and goods over longer distances. In recent years, high-speed rail links have seen

Transatlantic liners
Cunard Cruise Liners represented the height of luxurious travel for tourists crossing between Europe and the US during the interwar years.